The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Amid the chatter about negotiations between **Iran** and **America**, the war continued in the Middle East. Iran launched missiles at **Israel** while Israel said it struck ballistic-missile storage facilities and two headquarters of the intelligence arm of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps in Tehran. America said that it was also still striking Iranian targets. Meanwhile, Israel issued fresh evacuation orders to residents in parts of southern Lebanon.

The **Iranian** regime named **Mohammad Bagher Zolghadr** as secretary of the powerful Supreme National Security Council. He replaces Ali Larijani, who was killed in American-Israeli strikes. Mr Zolghadr is a retired commander of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. Unlike Mr Larijani, he has little experience negotiating with America. Meanwhile, Lebanon demanded the Iranian ambassador leave in a bid to rein in the Iran-backed Hizbullah militia group. He has until March 29th.

Apollo, a private-markets colossus, stopped paying out redemption requests from its main private-credit fund. Investors tried to withdraw $1.6bn, or 11.2% of assets, more than twice the company's 5% threshold. Apollo is the largest money manager to

face the private-credit crunch as investors worry about the riskiness of unlisted assets.

Australia and the **European Union** sealed a free-trade deal after eight years of negotiations. As part of the agreement almost all tariffs on European exports to Australia will be dropped. The EU expects exports to Australia to increase by a third over the next decade. The two sides also signed a security and defence deal last week.

Giorgia Meloni was defeated in a referendum on judicial reform. Italy's prime minister staked political capital on a proposal that opponents in effect turned into a vote of confidence on her leadership. Around 54% of voters came out against measures that critics say would have weakened the independence of courts. Ms Meloni believes the judiciary is hostile to her right-wing government.

Vietnam and **Russia** agreed to work together to build Vietnam's first nuclear-power plant. The deal was signed during a visit by Pham Minh, Vietnam's prime minister, to Moscow. The plant is expected to go live in 2031. Vietnam also signed a deal with Novatek, Russia's biggest LNG producer, as it seeks to bolster energy supplies amid the war in Iran.

A military transport aircraft crashed in dense jungle in southern **Colombia**, killing at least 66 people. The head of the armed forces called it a "tragic accident". Gustavo Petro, the president, criticised those blocking the modernisation of the army. "Why didn't they buy a new plane, just like they buy their cars and their flats?", he wrote on X. Colombia acquired the plane in 2020.

Figure of the day: 1926, the last year a living American president was put on a coin. Read about why Donald Trump also wants to put his face on money.

Photograph: AP

Donald Trump shifts gears on Iran

Having spent the weekend issuing dire threats against Iran's regime, on Monday Donald Trump changed tack. He posted on social media that he was suspending strikes against Iran's power plants and energy infrastructure. Furthermore, he announced that he was in talks with Iran (denied by the Iranians themselves) to achieve the "COMPLETE AND TOTAL RESOLUTION OF OUR HOSTILITIES". Big questions remain: is this a prelude to Mr Trump bailing out altogether, or the cue for more negotiations? And where does this leave America's ally, Israel?

Increasingly, Mr Trump's focus seems to be on averting a global energy crisis. Israel thus faces the prospect of the war ending without reaching its key objective of provoking a popular uprising to topple the Iranian regime. Instead, it is looking more likely that the ill-judged campaign will end messily, with an Iran that is damaged, but still able to inflict considerable damage on the region and the world.

Photograph: Reuters

Continental drift in Denmark’s election

Mette Frederiksen, Denmark’s prime minister, hoped that a snap general election on Tuesday would let her bank support for standing up to President Donald Trump’s threats to seize Greenland, a Danish territory. But even a Trump bump might not stop her party suffering its worst result in more than a century. Polls suggest Ms Frederiksen’s Social Democrats will get 21% of the vote, compared with 28% in 2022. Other parties in her governing coalition are also projected to suffer heavy losses.

Among the big winners will be parties from the populist left and right. The Danish People’s Party, a populist right-wing party, is projected to get 10% of the vote, up from less than 3%. The Green Left is projected to increase its share of the vote from 8% to almost 14%. This would leave both the left and right blocs a hair’s breadth from a majority and wooing the most likely kingmaker, the centrist Moderate party.

Photograph: Reuters

Xiaomi the money

After years of exceptional growth China's auto sales have been sluggish at the start of 2026. In February passenger-car sales fell by 26% year on year and 33% month on month. This is probably because many subsidies for electric vehicles expired at the end of last year. But another subsidy is never too far away in China's consumer market, and some are now being renewed. This, analysts say, should help revive growth.

To understand how individual companies fared last year, take a look at Xiaomi, a fresh entrant to the EV market. The company, one of China's most successful smartphone and consumer-device makers, reports its 2025 earnings on Tuesday. In 2024 it began selling sleek EVs and has been trying to keep up with demand ever since. Investors will be looking for signs that the company can maintain the pace. Lei Jun, Xiaomi's charismatic founder, might provide one with a forecast for EV sales in 2026.

What's next?

Xiaomi, market capitalisation, $bn

Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Reuters

Anthropic fights back against the Pentagon

On Tuesday a judge in California will hear a request by Anthropic, an AI lab, to put a preliminary halt to efforts by the Trump administration to blacklist it from government contracts and declare it a supply-chain risk. Anthropic will argue that the crackdown is illegal retaliation for its efforts to build safe AI. Led by the Pentagon, the government will counter that Anthropic is not a trusted partner and that it poses an unacceptable national-security risk.

The case stems from Anthropic's refusal to remove safeguards from its AI tools that prevent them being used for autonomous weapons and mass surveillance. But it will hinge on whether the judge decides that a draconian measure only previously applied to foreign adversaries is suitable for a contract dispute with an American firm. Lawyers, former generals and Microsoft, a tech giant, have weighed in on Anthropic's behalf, arguing that the Pentagon has gone too far.

Photograph: Reuters

Can Ilia Malinin pick himself up?

Perhaps the biggest shock of the Winter Olympics last month was Ilia Malinin's failure to win individual gold in figure skating. The American had won the previous two world championships and has pushed the sport's technical boundaries. In 2022, aged just 17, he was the first person to land a quad axel—a four-and-a-half turn jump—in a competition. But at the Olympics his choice of a difficult routine hurt him. He fell twice in his final skate and finished eighth. His rivals beat him by performing simpler tricks with greater accuracy.

The "Quad God" attributed his poor performance to the pressure of high expectations. "It just felt so overwhelming," he said. He has a chance to put things right at the World Championships, which began in Prague on Tuesday. Mikhail Shaidorov of Kazakhstan, who won the Olympic gold, is skipping the event. That may make Mr Malinin's quest a bit easier.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Clover, buckwheat and manuka are types of what food product?

Monday: Which 1971 album by Joni Mitchell is often rated as one of the greatest of all time?

Have nothing in your house that you do not know to be useful, or believe to be beautiful.

William Morris